

**Amazon One payment**

Amazon One is a new contactless payment service that scans your palm for authentication. <http://digit.in/oct20-27>

**Noise cancellation on Meet**

Noise cancellation that can block out background sounds is coming to Google Meet for mobile. <http://digit.in/oct20-28>



The state of the headphone market

A look into the Indian consumers' current state of mind when purchasing headphones

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eadphones are a form of escapism. They transform music listening into an intimate affair, and as the technological advancements in this space are burgeoning, consumers are no longer looking at headphones as an accompanying accessory they get along with their smartphones, but a solid investment that could fulfill their entertainment, work-related, calling, and even gaming needs. The rise of music streaming services such as Spotify, YouTube Music, Apple Music,

and others have also led to the astronomical popularity of headphones, which has made them into an extremely pervasive commodity.

Improvements and developments in the audio manufacturing industry are noticeable, where key players, and even emerging ones, are spending inordinate amounts of time tweaking and perfecting the appearance, sound quality, portability, and connectivity of headphones to make them even more lucrative purchases. Also, the growing popularity of wireless headphones, and the introduction of a relatively nascent category in 2016 – true wireless earphones, has seen brands releasing even more headphones per year, than ever before, to ensure they stay at the top of the game and offer appealing products in this explosive category. At this stage, consumers are spoilt for choice since a lot of brands are adding features such as voice assistant access, IP ratings, sports fit, NFC connectivity, wireless charging, and others, which were previously considered strictly 'premium'.

Owing to the growing popularity of audio products, the global earphones and headphones market is projected

to reach values of over \$36 billion by 2024, growing at a CAGR of approximately 13 percent during 2018-2024, as per Mobility India. So, how has this drastic change translated in the Indian scenario? Are users as receptive to buying headphones separately rather than use the free ones that are almost always packaged with smartphones? How has the Indian market reacted to the blooming true wireless segment? We conducted a survey to find out the Indian consumer state of mind when it comes to purchasing headphones and earphones. Let's delve right into it.

THE SHIFT FROM WIRED TO WIRELESS

Numerous headphone brands are vying for the top spot in the wireless audio category as people shift from the clutter of wires to ones that snap the cords completely. With the introduction of the AirPods in 2016 and the removal of the 3.5mm audio jack on most smartphones, the audio market started exploding with countless true wireless offerings, with even Indian companies such as Wings, Noise, and others bringing out affordable devices in this elusive category. In our survey, we found that 59 percent of the respondents still use wired headphones/earphones, however, for their next purchase a whopping 78.4 percent of the respondents said that they would be going down the wireless route. This really indicates the shift that the market has taken has boded well with the consumers in India as more and more of them are vying for the newer wireless technology as their next purchase.

Of the respondents that already use wireless earphones/headphones, about 38 percent own true wireless earbuds, 34 percent utilise wireless on- or over-ear headphones, while 28 percent use neckband style wireless earphones, giving a slight edge to the true wireless category. However, for their next purchase, the gap widens, with about 48 percent respondents saying that they will be going for the true wireless category. In our survey, Samsung, boAt, and JBL are the three most owned